

or developing circular manufacturing processes.”

An emphasis on research and development (R&D) or innovation can never be exaggerated, and it calls for a lot of perseverance. Shetty is quick to explain how India spends just 0.65% of its GDP on R&D. “It is 2.5% for China and 3% in case of the US. We are very good with services but must have products, which can come only from R&D and innovation,” he says. The solution is clear—invest more.

The more critical question is what some of the industries need to do? According to Ravee Chitoor, Professor of Strategy and International Business, Gustavon School of Business, University of Victoria, Canada, to become stronger means moving up the value chain. “Pharmaceutical companies are already quite international, but they need to move from generics to branded generics to more complex formulations and, ultimately, novel chemical entities backed by original research. Similarly, IT services need to adapt to AI-driven products and services and ultimately move into more value-added consulting,” he says.

In the context of IT, TCS’s Ramachandran points towards the pandemic to elucidate how much things have changed. “Before Covid, there was technology in every business. Since then, every business has become a technology business, and if you look at it today, every business is powered by technology.” Drawing a comparison between Y2K and the pandemic, he thinks the former brought Indian IT companies to the fore. “The prowess of technology from India came through (in Y2K), while Covid was about how technology could help businesses. The whole digitisation piece was more global, making it very significant,” he says. Understandably, going global entices India Inc not just for the scale that some markets offer. “It is enormous, especially in catego-



“That single product (Willys Jeep) would go on to define rural transportation in India and become a symbol of reliable power”

ANISH SHAH
Group CEO & MD,
Mahindra Group



“Our companies are now being recognised as high-value strategic partners and not just cost-efficient manufacturers”

DIPALI GOENKA
MD & CEO,
Welspun Living

ries like bed, bath, and home solutions. It naturally pushes us to think beyond borders, not just for more market share but to stay close to the people whom we serve,” says Welspun’s Goenka.

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To be fair, this journey, while being impressive, has a long way to go. India has only nine companies in the 2024 Fortune Global 500 list, while China has 128, Chitoor explains. “Even smaller economies like Canada and the Netherlands have 14 and 11 companies, respectively,” he says.

There is little to doubt the potential of our domestic market, but if companies want to be global multinationals, an aggressive approach outside India is necessary. “Many new-age companies like Alphabet and Shopify are born global, in the sense that they look to establish their presence in international markets early in life.” To do that, Indian companies need to step up on both resources and capabilities in the spheres of marketing/branding or technology/R&D. “Quality of people is a very important factor. Like Korea and China, did decades ago, India should consciously attract the best talent from across the world by creating enabling conditions,” he adds.

Across industries, the mindset surrounding global expansion has undergone a significant shift. It is not a discretionary choice but a strategic imperative. L&T’s Sarma says a worldwide presence derisks the business. “That provides natural hedging, be it geographic, economic, or sectoral. More importantly, the approach creates an opportunity to benchmark ourselves against the best in the world,” he says. For L&T, that makes it stronger domestically. “Exposure to global best practices translates into higher value creation back home. In many ways, a global presence becomes a catalyst for overall organisational maturity and excellence.”

If GDP is a barometer, there is reason to be happy. From \$2.4 trillion at the